

democracy is large enough to accommodate the Capitalist and the Commissar.

I believe our theme, as in the past, reads the pulse of the times. One issue that concentrates the global mind at the moment—I'm sure you will agree with me—is the issue of leadership. As we all know, a thrilling leadership battle is being played out in the world's most influential democracy. We need only to look at the Democratic primaries in America to get some pointers to what different leaders are offering. The defining words on the stump are words like Change vs Continuity, Hope vs Experience, Dream vs Reality, Freedom vs Security and Privilege vs Entitlement. We need only to look at President George Bush's moral adventurism to realise how

his post-9/11 leadership has divided the public opinion at home and abroad. And how it set the stage for a new debate on America's place in the world—and on war, freedom and national sovereignty.

Let me quote Barack Obama, the freshman senator who wants to become the next President of the United States: "This century's threats are at least as dangerous as and in some ways more complex than those we have confronted in the past. These threats demand a new vision of leadership in the 21st century—a vision that draws from the past but is not bound by outdated thinking." Outdated thinking—I would say they are the operative words. The new century demands a new approach from our leadership class.

The awareness is apparent in countries that have undergone a change of guard recently. Nicolas

Sarkozy in post-Chirac France is known not only for his bling-bling presidency or his romantic conquests. As a bold reformer, he has targeted the many privileges of the welfare state. In the United Kingdom, after a superb beginning, the man who has inherited the mantle from Tony Blair is desperately trying to halt the rising popularity of his young Conservative challenger. Even in Russia, the strong leader had to make a kind of democratic gesture by appointing a successor, although there is no dispute over who holds the real power. In the People's Republic of China, changes are never dramatic, and faces don't fade out that easily. Still, we can't miss a gradual generational shift in the higher echelons of the country. And, the leadership is getting more sensitive to the public sentiment. That is a big change in China.

Leadership is the issue that resonates across India's borders, too. In Pakistan particularly today. Even in a bonsai democracy, democracy is an ideal worth fighting for. And worth dying for too. Benazir Bhutto, the gala dinner speaker at the last Conclave, promised she would return if elected prime minister. She told us: "I am committed to bringing peace between our two countries. We cannot fail our children." Sadly, she was denied a chance. Her homecoming came to an abrupt and tragic end. It was an unsolicited martyrdom in a merciless land, where hate settled the argument on leadership. We will miss her.

Next door, as Nepal prepares for a post-Monarchy era, the question is all about the alternative. Is a Maoist Nepal the ideal in this century? The question has to be answered democratically, not the revolutionary way.

India too, will soon decide who should be leading the nation next. In the true Indian tradition, the General Elections would be a referendum on competing ideas of India. The much celebrated India of a million possibilities requires a leadership whose gaze extends beyond the expediencies of short-term politics. We need a leadership which is bold, energetic, impatient and willing to shed the burdens of the past. The last century was a grand narrative of extreme passions. Its history was shaped by revolutions, liberations and exterminations. Nations were born, built and subjugated. It was an age of leaders larger than life. Leaders with a capital L. The most messianic of them promised heaven on earth, and gave hell. There were revolutionaries, freedom fighters, nation builders, mass murderers, and war mongers. They were a formidable lot, driven by dreams and fantasy, idealism and ideology. Gandhi, Lenin, Mao, Hitler, Stalin, Churchill, de Gaulle, Truman, Kennedy, Reagan, Thatcher, Mrs Gandhi, Gorbachev....I can go on and on. We are yet to outlive their legacies, for better or for worse.

We are still in the first glow of the 21st century, and the challenges it illuminates are no less intimidating. They are more than political and economic. They are cultural, digital, ecological, religious, scientific and ethical. The new century needs a leadership that is not subordinated to ideology but ideas.

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Full speech at:

<http://www.indiatodayconclave.com>

